

Couture Corsetry

Guide to Working with Sheer Tulle



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How to stabilize, cut and sew tulle with less stretching and more control, from the first cut to the last seam.

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1 · Get to know your tulle before you cut it

Corsetry mostly uses three kinds of tulle. Each one needs different handling:

Type	What it is like	What it is for
Stiff tulle (nylon, petticoat net)	Rough, with lots of body	Volume; not suitable against the skin.
Illusion tulle / soft tulle	Fine, drapes, almost invisible on the skin	Sheer panels, “illusion” necklines, outer layers.
Corsetry mesh (non-stretch firm mesh or tulle)	Fine but does not give	Sheer panels that do structural work: they can take bones.

Stretch test. Take 10 cm (4 in) of tulle in each direction and stretch it gently. The direction that stretches least runs along the panel (parallel to the grainline arrow on the pattern). For a panel under tension, choose a tulle that barely stretches in any direction.

2 · Tools that make the difference

- ☐ Rotary cutter and cutting mat: it cuts without lifting the fabric.
- ☐ Pattern weights (or cans) instead of pins.
- ☐ Extra-fine pins or sewing clips for joining.
- ☐ Tissue paper or parchment paper to sew on top of.
- ☐ Water-soluble stabilizer (optional, for very delicate edges).
- ☐ Fine new needles: 60/8 or 70/10, microtex type.
- ☐ Fine polyester thread in the color of the tulle or one shade darker.

3 · Stabilizing: keeping the tulle still

- 1 Work on a large table, without the tulle hanging over the edge: its weight distorts it.
- 2 Lay the tulle on tissue paper. If you need to mark, mark on the paper, not on the tulle.
- 3 For very delicate panels, mist lightly with spray starch, let it dry and press with a warm iron: the tulle becomes easier to handle and the starch comes out in the first wash.

- 4 If the panel goes over another fabric, baste the tulle to that fabric in the seam allowance before cutting the final outline.

4 · Cutting with precision

- 1 Transfer the pattern to paper and place the tulle and paper together, with the grainline arrow well aligned.
- 2 Hold it down with weights. If you use pins, put them only inside the seam allowance.
- 3 Cut with a rotary cutter, one movement per edge, without lifting the fabric.
- 4 Mark notches with a 2 mm (1/16 in) snip or with a colored thread mark: chalk does not show on tulle.
- 5 Keep each cut piece flat, with its paper, until you sew it.

5 · Machine, needle and stitch

Setting	Recommendation
Needle	60/8 or 70/10 microtex, new for each garment.
Stitch length	2 to 2.5 mm. Shorter puckers; longer opens up.
Tension	One step lower than for cotton. Test on a scrap.
Presser foot	Straight-stitch or Teflon foot; lower the foot pressure if your machine allows it.
Starting a seam	Start on a strip of paper or hold the threads at the back so the tulle is not pulled into the needle plate.

Sew on top of paper. Stitch with the tissue paper under the tulle and tear it away carefully afterwards. It is the simplest way to stop the fabric stretching or puckering.

6 · Clean seams on a fabric that shows on both sides

On tulle every seam is on show. Choose the finish according to where it goes:

French seam

Sew wrong sides together at 5 mm (3/16 in), trim to 2 mm, fold and sew right sides together at 4 mm (1/8 in). It leaves a fine, neat channel. Ideal for straight sheer panels.

Taped seam

Sew as normal, trim to 5 mm and cover the allowance with tulle or organza tape in the same color. Works for curved seams.

Illusion seam

Against the skin, use skin-tone tulle and minimal finishes: a double row of stitching at 3 mm (1/8 in) and trim close.

Overlaid

To join tulle and lace: lay the lace on top, sew with a fine zigzag following the motif and trim the tulle away underneath.

7 · Boning channels on tulle

- 1 Use channel tape or 1.5 cm (5/8 in) strips of coutil sewn on the inside: tulle alone cannot hold a bone.
- 2 If you want the structure to show, choose tape in the same shade as the outer fabric and sew it straight, with an even line of stitching on each side.
- 3 For tulle corset panels, use firm corsetry mesh and fine spiral bones (5 or 7 mm / 3/16 or 1/4 in).
- 4 Secure the ends of each channel with a few hand stitches so the bone does not poke through.

8 · Pressing and finishing

- ☐ Iron on a low setting (synthetics) and always with a cotton pressing cloth in between.
- ☐ Press, do not drag: dragging the iron distorts the tulle.
- ☐ Free edges: finish with folded tulle bias, a 2 mm (1/16 in) rolled hem or a lace edge.
- ☐ Elasticated edges: use fine picot elastic and a narrow zigzag.
- ☐ Check against the light: that is how you spot loose threads and uneven allowances.

9 · Common mistakes and how to avoid them

Problem	Why it happens	Solution
The panel ended up longer than the pattern	The tulle stretched while cutting or sewing	Cut on paper and sew on top of the paper.
Puckered seam	Short stitch or high tension	2.5 mm stitch and less tension; test on a scrap.
The machine “eats” the tulle	Thick needle or starting without support	60/8 needle and start on paper.
Holes along the seams	Worn or damaged needle	A new needle for each garment.
Allowances that look uneven	Trimmed by eye	Trim with a ruler and rotary cutter, or use a French seam.

Next step

Before your next corset with tulle, cut a 20 × 20 cm (8 × 8 in) scrap and test the needle, the stitch and the finish you plan to use. When the test seam lies flat and neat, move on to the garment.